The `Content-Type` header describes the data sent in a request or response. It contains the MIME type of the data, with an optional character encoding. For example, the `application/json; charset=utf-8` header would indicate that the body of the request or response is JSON, encoded using UTF-8.

For more on MIME types, see the Mozilla documentation: http://mng.bz/gop8. You can find the RFC for content negotiation at http://mng.bz/6DXo.

You're not forced into sending only a `Content-Type` the client expects, and in some cases, you may not even be able to handle the types it requests. What if a request stipulates that it can accept only Microsoft Excel spreadsheets? It's unlikely you'd support that, even if that's the only `Accept` type the request contains.

When you return an API model from an action method, whether directly (as in listing 20.13) or via an `OkResult` or other `StatusCodeResult`, ASP.NET Core always returns something in the response. If it can't honor any of the types stipulated in the `Accept` header, it will fall back to returning JSON by default. Figure 20.7 shows that even though XML was requested, the API controller formatted the response as JSON.